

GERUNDS

The Verb that Works as a Noun | SSC CGL English

What is a Gerund

Functions

Gerund vs Infinitive

Common Exam Traps

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What is a Gerund?

A gerund is a **Verb + ing** form that does the work of a **NOUN**.

Form

Verb (V1) + ing

swim → swimming | read → reading

Function

Works like a noun:

subject, object, or complement

Swimming is good exercise. *(gerund used as the subject)*

💡 Remember: Every gerund ends in -ing, but every -ing word is NOT a gerund!

What is a Gerund?

A gerund is **Base form + ing (-ing Form)** that is not functioning as a verb

Base (V1) + ing

swim → swimming | read → reading

He is (be-auxiliary) swimming

**His hobby IS (Stative/ Action Verb)
swimming**

Swimming is good for health. *(gerund used as the subject)*

💡 Remember: Every gerund ends in -ing, but every -ing word is NOT a gerund!

Gerund vs Present Participle

Same form, different job.

GERUND → acts as a NOUN

Smoking is injurious to health.
(subject of the sentence)

He loves painting.
(object of the verb 'loves')

PARTICIPLE → verb / adjective

He is smoking now.
(part of the continuous tense)

A smiling child ran to me.
(describes the noun 'child')

💡 Test: Replace the -ing word with 'it' or 'this'. If the sentence still makes sense, it is a GERUND.

Functions of a Gerund

1. Subject

Walking improves health.

2. Object of the Verb

She enjoys reading.

3. Object of a Preposition

He is fond of singing.

4. Complement

My hobby is painting.

💡 In every case, the gerund is doing a NOUN's job in the sentence.

Verbs Followed by a Gerund

These verbs take V1 + ing, never 'to + verb'

enjoy

avoid

mind

suggest

finish

admit

deny

consider

postpone

risk

practise

miss

dislike

keep

imagine

resist

He avoided meeting me. | She suggested going by train.

✗ He suggested to go. ✓ He suggested going.

Preposition + Gerund

A verb after a preposition must take the -ing form

fond of

good at

tired of

interested in

insist on

refrain from

succeed in

prevent from

She is good at painting.

He insisted on paying the bill.

The rain prevented us from going out.

💡 Rule: Preposition + V1-ing.

The 'TO' Trap

In these phrases 'to' is a PREPOSITION, so the gerund follows

look forward to

accustomed to

addicted to

used to (be/get)

object to

devoted to

prone to

with a view to

averse to

✓ I look forward to meeting you.

✗ I look forward to meet you.

☆ One of the most repeated question patterns in SSC CGL!

Gerund vs Infinitive: Meaning Changes

Some verbs take both, but the meaning changes

STOP

He stopped smoking.

He gave up the habit.

He stopped to smoke.

He paused in order to smoke.

REMEMBER

I remember posting the letter.

Past action, already done.

Remember to post the letter.

Future duty, not yet done.

TRY

Try opening the window.

Do it as an experiment.

He tried to open the window.

He made an effort.

Possessive Before a Gerund

Use my, your, his, her, their, or noun + 's before a gerund

✓ I appreciate your coming on time.

✗ I appreciate you coming on time.

There is no chance of his winning the match.

We were surprised at Ravi's refusing the offer.

They objected to my sitting there.

💡 SSC prefers the possessive form before a gerund in formal English.

Common SSC Error Patterns

✗ He suggested to go home.

✓ He suggested going home.

✗ She avoided to meet him.

✓ She avoided meeting him.

✗ I look forward to hear from you.

✓ I look forward to hearing from you.

✗ He is used to work at night.

✓ He is used to working at night.

✗ Would you mind to open the door?

✓ Would you mind opening the door?

Quick Comparison: The Three Forms

Form	Looks like	Acts as a...	Example
Gerund	V1 + ing	Noun	Reading is fun.
Present Participle	V1 + ing	Verb part / Adjective	The boy is reading.
Infinitive	to + V1	Noun / Adj / Adverb	He wants to read.

💡 The FORM can be identical. Always judge by the FUNCTION in the sentence.

Tips to Identify a Gerund

1

Find the -ing word

Underline every V1 + ing word in the sentence.

2

Check its JOB

Is it working as a subject, object, or complement? Then it is a gerund.

3

Apply the 'it' test

Replace the -ing word with 'it'. If the sentence survives, it is a gerund.

4

Look for a preposition before it

Preposition + -ing is always a gerund (fond of singing).

5

Watch the special verbs

enjoy, avoid, mind, suggest, finish + -ing form.

Let's Practise: Spot the Gerund!

Q1. Jogging keeps you fit.

Jogging
Subject

Q2. He admitted stealing the money.

stealing
Object of the verb

Q3. She is afraid of driving at night.

driving
Object of the preposition

Q4. His weakness is eating sweets.

eating
Complement

🚀 Now it is TEST TIME! 10 MCQs in the SSC CGL pattern. Get ready!

Question 1

1. *"SWIMMING is the best exercise." The word in capitals is a/an:*

A Infinitive

B Present Participle

C Gerund

D Adjective

Answer 1

1. *"SWIMMING is the best exercise." The word in capitals is a/an:*

✓ CORRECT ANSWER: C) Gerund

📖 Explanation:

"Swimming" is the subject of the sentence. It is a V1 + ing form doing the work of a noun, so it is a Gerund.

Question 2

2. Choose the grammatically correct sentence.

A He suggested going home.

B He suggested to go home.

C He suggested go home.

D He suggested for going home.

Answer 2

2. Choose the grammatically correct sentence.

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: A) He suggested going home.**

Explanation:

The verb 'suggest' is always followed by a gerund, never an infinitive. So 'He suggested going home.' is correct.

Question 3

3. *"I look forward to ____ you soon."*

A meet

B met

C have met

D meeting

Answer 3

3. "I look forward to ____ you soon."

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: D) meeting**

Explanation:

In 'look forward to', the word 'to' is a **PREPOSITION**, not an infinitive marker. A preposition is always followed by a gerund: 'meeting'.

Question 4

4. *"He is used to ____ hard for his exams."*

A work

B working

C worked

D works

Answer 4

4. "He is used to ____ hard for his exams."

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: B) working**

Explanation:

'Be used to' means 'accustomed to'. Here 'to' is a preposition, so the gerund 'working' follows. Compare: 'He used to work' (past habit) takes V1.

Question 5

5. "My favourite hobby is COLLECTING stamps." The gerund works as a/an:

A Subject

B Object of the verb

C Object of a preposition

D Complement

Answer 5

5. "My favourite hobby is **COLLECTING** stamps." The gerund works as a/an:

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: D) Complement**

Explanation:

'Collecting stamps' comes after the verb 'is' and completes the meaning of the subject 'hobby'. A noun form after 'be' is a Complement.

Question 6

6. "He stopped _____ because the doctor warned him." (He gave up the habit.)

A smoking

B to smoke

C smoke

D smoked

Answer 6

6. "He stopped ____ because the doctor warned him." (He gave up the habit.)

✓ CORRECT ANSWER: **A)** smoking

Explanation:

'Stop + gerund' means to give up the activity. 'Stop + infinitive' means to pause in order to do something. Since he quit the habit, 'stopped smoking' is correct.

Question 7

7. Which sentence contains a *GERUND* (not a participle)?

A The crying baby needs milk.

B She is singing a song.

C Dancing is her passion.

D A rolling stone gathers no moss.

Answer 7

7. Which sentence contains a **GERUND** (not a participle)?

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: C) Dancing is her passion.**

Explanation:

In 'Dancing is her passion', 'Dancing' is the subject (a noun job), so it is a gerund. In A and D the -ing words describe nouns (adjectives); in B it forms the continuous tense.

Question 8

8. "Would you mind _____ the door?"

A to close

B closing

C close

D closed

Answer 8

8. "Would you mind ____ the door?"

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: B) closing**

Explanation:

The verb 'mind' is always followed by a gerund. 'Would you mind closing the door?' is the correct polite request form.

Question 9

9. Choose the correct sentence (possessive rule).

A I insisted on him apologise.

B I insisted on he apologising.

C I insisted to his apologising.

D I insisted on his apologising.

Answer 9

9. Choose the correct sentence (possessive rule).

✓ CORRECT ANSWER: D) I insisted on his apologising.

📖 Explanation:

A gerund takes a POSSESSIVE before it: 'his apologising'. The verb 'insist' takes the preposition 'on', and the preposition is followed by the gerund.

Question 10

10. "The heavy rain prevented us from ____ out."

A going

B go

C to go

D went

Answer 10

10. *"The heavy rain prevented us from ____ out."*

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: A) going**

Explanation:

'Prevent' takes the structure prevent + object + from + gerund. After the preposition 'from', only the -ing form 'going' is correct.

What You've Learned!

- ✦ A gerund is Verb + ing working as a NOUN.
- 🔍 Same -ing form, different job: gerund = noun, participle = verb/adjective.
- Gerunds work as subject, object, object of preposition, or complement.
- enjoy, avoid, mind, suggest, finish... always take the gerund.
- ⚠️□ look forward to, used to (be), object to... 'to' is a preposition here, so use -ing.
- stop, remember, try change meaning with gerund vs infinitive.
- ★ Use the possessive before a gerund: 'I appreciate your coming.'

Keep practising and you will master Gerund! ✨